

The Last Word

Customer first

THIS YEAR, I spent two nights in Jaipur, one of my favourite cities here. On the second of these evenings, a couple of days before writing this, I wanted to eat something authentically local. There was just such a dish listed on the menu of the Handi Restaurant. I ordered it, and was told that it was spicy! "Fine", I said, "I just want it done normally, no change." When it came it was rather insipid and I just thought I had ended up in a bad restaurant. But, at the end of the meal, prompted by my wife, I asked about this. To my surprise, I was told that the chef had thought I would not like the normal dish, and had made it bland for me, directly contradicting my order!

I was furious, and made it very clear that I felt cheated, and that I would not pay for that dish. The chef then sent from the kitchen, samples of the sauce that was served to me, and of the one that I should have been given! A huge difference. So, I was particularly surprised when the errant dish appeared on the bill, and I was expected to pay for it. Much argument followed, and I ended up accusing the manager of racism and threatening to call the police before it was deducted from the bill. I have no idea what the police would have made of all this fuss, and I am quite sure the restaurant gave in mainly because of the attention the other diners were giving to all the noise.

In the UK, we have an old saying that "The customer is always right", and here in India we have the famous quote from Gandhi about the customer being the "most important visitor on our premises..." But during the last three months I have heard a surprising number of stories from people here about very poor after-sales service for IT products — specifically, poor service when something goes wrong, even if the product is still within warranty.

Of course, poor service can be found all over the world, but so many have now told me that it is of particular concern here. It is something we wish to investigate further. Naturally, our interest is limited to the IT industry (and restaurants).

I must say that in my own experience, if you want bad customer service in India, you just need to open a bank account. But with the IT industry, having purchased one PC, two laptops and a few peripherals from a small dealership in Nehru Place, New Delhi, the service that I have received has been better here than anywhere else. Better than I usually get in the UK, where I have bought much more equipment over the years.

So, what is going on? I have spoken to quite a few people in the industry about this issue, and they make very different observations. At one extreme, they tell me that many consumers don't know the law and their rights and are therefore unable to exercise those rights when something goes wrong. At the other extreme, I have been told that consumers' expectations here are higher than elsewhere — China was mentioned as being similar to India in this respect — to an extent that is probably unreasonable. They therefore complain about not getting the service they think they deserve.

It has long been my view that good customer service helps the vendors as much as it does the customer, and generally helps drive the industry towards better quality. And magazines like ours should help drive this process. Vendors that I speak to, generally tell me that they welcome complaints from customers because this helps them deliver a better service. Yes, they would say that, wouldn't they? But it is also the only way they can find out where they need to improve.

One thing that I have been saying to these people is that we will invite



Edward Henning, Editor-in-Chief

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Digit readers to let us know when they have serious problems.

So please do this. If you have a genuine example of truly bad service, such as a product going wrong within warranty and the supplier refusing to fix or replace it, then please let us know at: servicewatch@thinkdigit.com. Make sure that you have proper documentation (receipt, etc.) to back up your complaint. We cannot promise even to reply to all the emails we will receive, but we will pick a selection and take them up with the relevant companies at the highest level. Some of the examples that you send us — of both good and bad service — will be reported in the magazine or on our web site. I doubt I will find another restaurant with as bad a service as I received at the Handi in Jaipur, but who knows, maybe we'll start a restaurant column as well.

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "E. Henning".

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